2020. In Maharashtra, the erstwhile Uddhav Thackeray-led government had a face-off with Governor Bhagat Singh Koshyari over the appointment of the Speaker. In Telangana, Governor Tamilisai Soundararajan and Chief Minister K. Chandrasekhar Rao had unsavoury public spats even on issues such as visits to flood-affected areas.

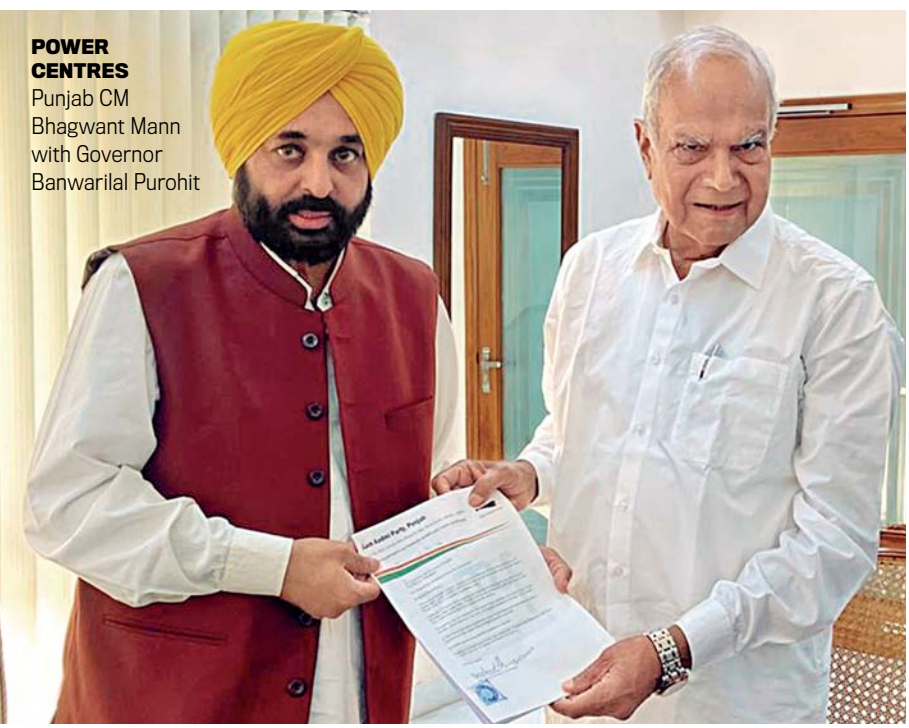
THE WAR OVER V-Cs

The appointment of V-Cs has emerged as an especially contentious issue, not just in Kerala, but also in other states such as West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Punjab. In Punjab, Governor Purohit termed the appointment of Satbir Singh Gosal, a well-known biotechnologist, as the V-C of Punjab Agricultural University in Ludhiana as "illegal" and asked CM Mann to remove him from the post immediately. The governor's diktat to the chief minister came just a week after Purohit refused to accept the state government's choice for the Punjab Agriculture University of Baba Farid University of Health Sciences in Faridkot. The state government had appointed cardiologist Dr Gurpreet Singh Wander, but Purohit rejected the appointment on October 11, asking the government to send a panel of three candidates for the V-C's selection.

APPOINTMENT OF V-Cs HAS EMERGED AS A MAJOR BONE OF CONTENTION BETWEEN GOVERNORS AND SOME STATE GOVERNMENTS

Such conflicts happened in the past too, with non-BJP governments in power at the Centre. In Kerala in 1980, Governor Jothi Venkatachalam, a former Congress leader from Tamil Nadu, appointed A.V. Varghese as the Kerala University V-C, against the wishes of then CM E.K. Nayanar. Nearly a decade later, chief minister Nayanar had a run-in with another governor, Ram Dulari Sinha, who made some appointments to the senate of Calicut University. In 1984, West Bengal governor A.P. Sharma rejected then chief minister Jyoti Basu's nominees for Calcutta and Burdwan universities and selected others for the posts. An enraged Basu passed an amendment to curtail the chancellor's powers, which Sharma refused to sign. Eventually, the Union government had to ask Sharma to resign. The next year, Tamil Nadu governor S.L. Khurana declined to appoint C.A. Perumal—suggested by the M.G. Ramachandran-led AIADMK government—as the V-C of Madurai Kamaraj University and appointed S. Krishnaswamy instead.

Such conflicts are rooted in the intent of the political class to have an ideological grip over the higher education sector, and have often been the most intense when the Centre and the states have governments with almost diametrically opposite ideologies. If the Left government of Kerala has dubbed Governor Khan's recent actions as the Raj Bhavan's attempt to impose the RSS's Hindu-majoritarian agenda in Kerala, then Bengal Governor Jagdeep Dhankhar had publicly lambasted the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress government over the alleged politicisation of the education sector and appointment of undeserving candidates as V-Cs.



POWER CENTRES Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann with Governor Banwarilal Purohit

WHO GOVERNS THE V-Cs?

Ironically, the original intent of making governors hold the office of chancellor and vesting them with some statutory powers was to insulate universities from political influence. And the UGC regulations are the standard guidelines for appointing V-Cs. According to the UGC regulations, the "visitor/ chancellor", who is mostly the governor in states, shall appoint the V-C out of the panel of names recommended by the search-cum-selection committees. In March, the Supreme Court also held that the state governments are required to follow the UGC regulations, which is a central legislation, in case of a conflict between the state and central legislations. Several governors in recent times, including Khan, have raised questions